Topic 23 — Political & Map-Based Geography

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Political: UNCLOS (12/24/200) | India's neighbours | Boundary lines | Coastline | Capitals | Landlocked / equator | Geographical sobriquets **Map:** Seas · gulfs · bays | Straits | Canals | Mountains | Rivers / lakes | Ports | Köppen (कोपेन) (map climate)

Sources baked in: Lucent political + atlas match-lists; UNCLOS basics; coaching boundary-line / landlocked map; **Ghatnachakra** World Geography (borders · capitals · landlocked · dependent territories · old names · world towns · geographical sobriquets CB–84+ / CB–112+); UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★★ — 12/24/200 nm, McMahon/Radcliffe/Durand, capitals, landlocked, sobriquets, country ranks, Horn/Balkans, Köppen/Mediterranean **Last verified:** August 2026 — GC political-map pass **Current Affairs:** none mandatory (nm limits are static); Gaza / Horn conflict stems stay map-first

Current Affairs (this topic)

None mandatory. 12 / 24 / 200 nm are static.

UKPCS Prelims 2025

Q. UKPCS Prelims 2025, Q89

What is the correct latitudinal extent of the mainland of India?

A. 6 degrees 45′ N to 37 degrees 6′ N B. 6 degrees 4′ N to 36 degrees 7′ N C. 8 degrees 4′ N to 36 degrees 12′ N D. 8 degrees 4′ N to 37 degrees 6′ N

Show answer

Logic: Mainland excludes islands — southern limit is Kanyakumari (कन्याकुमारी), not Indira Point (इंदिरा पॉइंट). **Ans: D (Series B provisional key).** Mainland: 8°4′N to 37°6′N. 6°4′N is Indira Point (islands).

N.0 Framework — Political & Map Geography

Identity: This chapter is the **atlas + UNCLOS** home. Distances, boundary lines, capitals, landlocked status and chokepoints all live here.

Fact **12 / 24 / 200** nautical miles before any EEZ story.

India's neighbours need **land versus maritime** and **longest / shortest** borders.

Boundary lines need **countries + year + person** where Lucent gives them.

Map sections on seas, straits, canals, mountains, ports and Köppen are **match-list** homes.

Give one identity line for each pair.

Detailed world rivers and industries live in their own world chapters.

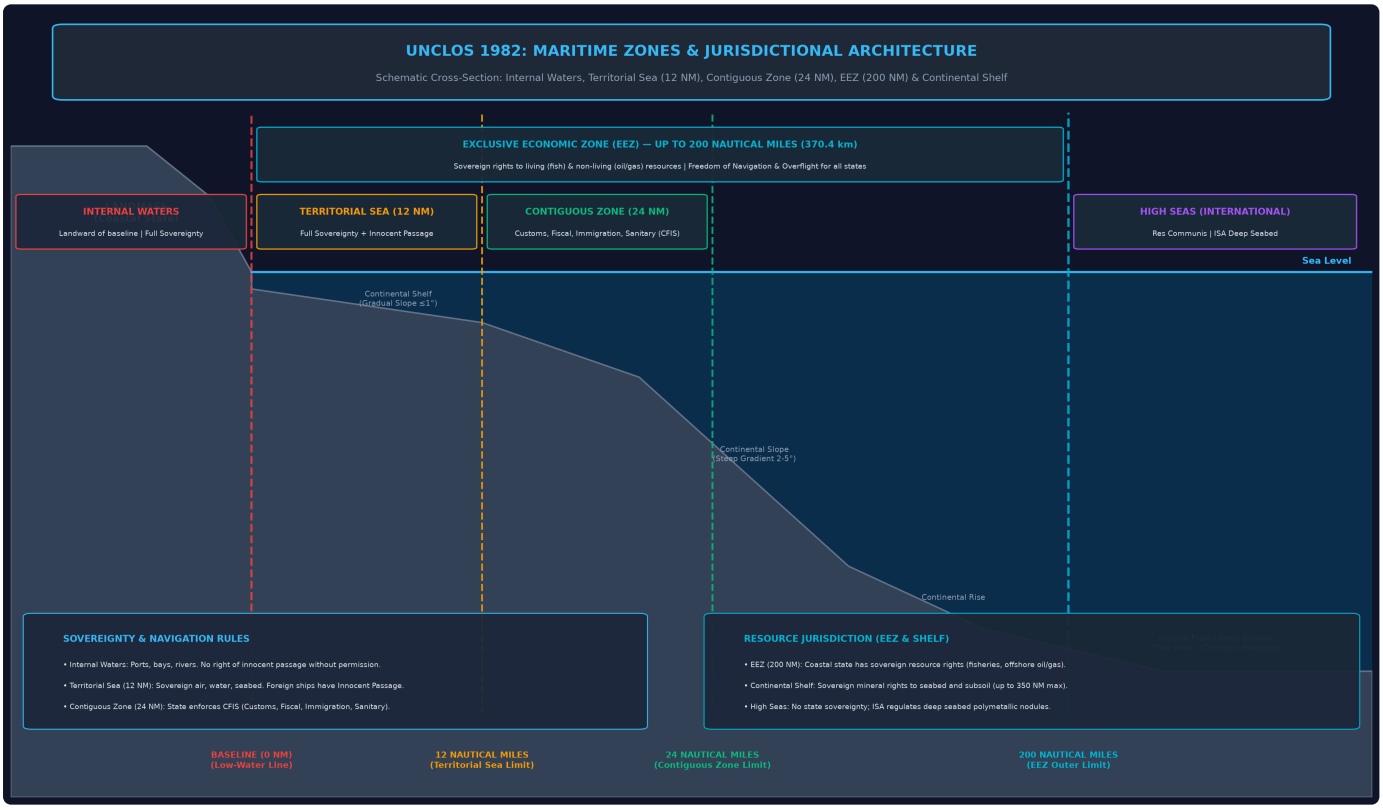
Here keep only the map associations that papers still match.

Order of this chapter

1. UNCLOS → neighbours → India map → boundary lines → coastline.
2. Capitals → sobriquets → landlocked / equator → seas → straits → canals.
3. Mountains → rivers/lakes → ports → Köppen.

Teach the **full political atlas**. Next year can ask any Lucent capital or strait, not only McMahon or Suez.

N.1 UNCLOS



Adopted (अंगीकृत): 1982 · **in force:** 1994 · **India:** 1995

Zones are measured from baselines. The normal baseline is the low-water line. One nautical mile is about **1.852 km**.

- **Internal waters** inside the baselines are under full sovereignty — ports and lagoons included.
- The **territorial sea** extends **12 nm**. The coastal state has full sovereignty. Foreign ships (नावाध्यक्ष) get **innocent passage**.
- The **contiguous zone** extends **24 nm** from the baseline for customs, fiscal, immigration and sanitary control.

- The **EEZ** extends **200 nm**. The coastal state has sovereign rights over **resources** (fish, oil, wind). That is not the same as owning the sea like land.
- The **continental shelf** is at least **200 nm**. Geology can take seabed rights to **350 nm**. Water above that extra shelf is **not** extra EEZ.
- The **high seas** lie beyond national zones and keep freedom of navigation.
- **The Area** is the seabed beyond national jurisdiction — the common heritage of mankind. The **ISA** headquarters is in Kingston, Jamaica.
- **Innocent passage** applies in the territorial sea.
- **Transit passage** applies in international straits. It is stronger and cannot be switched off like innocent passage.
- Archipelagic sea-lane passage is the Indonesia / Philippines type.
- India's EEZ is about **2.02 million km²**. The coastline with islands is about **7,516.6 km**.
- Later high-seas treaties do **not** rewrite the 12 / 24 / 200 yardsticks.

N.2 India's neighbours

Identity: India has **seven land neighbours** and **two maritime neighbours**.

Land: 7 · **Maritime:** 2

India's land neighbours are Pakistan, **Afghanistan**, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Myanmar and Bangladesh.

India's maritime neighbours are **Sri Lanka** and the **Maldives**.

Sri Lanka sits across the **Palk Strait / Gulf of Mannar**.

The Maldives sits across the **8° Channel**.

Sri Lanka, the Maldives and Tajikistan are **not** land neighbours.

The **Wakhan** corridor note keeps Afghanistan as a land neighbour via the PoK / Wakhan framing.

India's **longest** land border is with **Bangladesh**.

India's **shortest** land border is with **Afghanistan**.

Pakistan-facing states and UTs include Gujarat, Rajasthan, Punjab and J&K / Ladakh (लद्दाख).

China-facing units include Ladakh, Himachal (हिमाचल) Pradesh, Uttarakhand (उत्तराखंड), Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh.

Nepal-facing states include Uttarakhand, **Uttar Pradesh**, Bihar, West Bengal and Sikkim.

Bhutan-facing states include Sikkim, West Bengal, Assam and Arunachal Pradesh.

Myanmar-facing states include Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur and Mizoram.

Bangladesh-facing states include West Bengal, Assam, Meghalaya (मेघालय), Tripura and Mizoram.

Among foreign countries, **Uttar Pradesh** touches **Nepal only**.

N.2b India on the world map

Identity: India is a large **south Asian** peninsula between the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal.

Area: about **3.28 million km²**, which is **2.4%** of world land. India ranks **7th** largest (not 6th).

The Tropic of Cancer (**23½° N**) runs through the **middle** of the country.

Eight states sit on it: Gujarat, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Tripura and Mizoram.

The Tropic of Cancer does **not** pass through **Uttar Pradesh**.

It does **not** pass through **Ladakh** (लद्दाख).

India is **not** wholly tropical.

The north goes well beyond 23½° N, so a “fully tropical India” statement is false.

India’s standard meridian (मानक याम्योत्तर) is **82°30′ E** on the Mirzapur (मिर्ज़ापुर) / Prayagraj (प्रयागराज) belt.

That meridian defines **IST**.

The northern extreme is Indira Col (इंदिरा कोल) / Kashmir.

The southern extreme is **Indira Point** in the Andaman (अंडमान) and Nicobar (निकोबार) Islands.

The western extreme is **Ghuar Mota** in Gujarat.

The eastern extreme is **Kibithu** in Arunachal Pradesh.

N.3 Boundary lines

McMahon Line, 1914

Between: India and China (Arunachal / Tibet) · **Person:** Henry McMahon · **Conference:** Simla

- Eastern Himalaya (हिमालय) alignment. China disputes it.
- Paper spelling may be **MacMohan**.
- **Not** the Pakistan, Nepal, or Myanmar line (2018).

Durand Line, 1893

Between: British India and Afghanistan → today **Pakistan–Afghanistan** · **Person:** Mortimer Durand

- Not India–China. Not McMahon.

Radcliffe Line, 1947

Between: India–Pakistan and India–East Pakistan (**Bangladesh**) · **Person:** Cyril Radcliffe

- Partition boundary. Not 1914.

Other lines (one home)

- **LoC** — India–Pakistan in J&K (ceasefire line, later LoC). Not McMahon.

- **LAC** — India–China actual control in the west/middle. Not Radcliffe.
- **Sir Creek** — India–Pakistan creek, Kutch/Sindh; maritime.
- Johnson / McDonald lines — Aksai Chin claim-story.

World lines

Line	Note
49th Parallel	Long USA–**Canada** international border (not USA–Mexico)
38th Parallel	**North Korea–South Korea** armistice border
Maginot Line	Historical **France–Germany** fortification line (WWII)
Oder–Neisse Line	**Germany–Poland** post-WWII border
Hindenburg Line	WWI German boundary line between Germany and Poland/Russia
Mannerheim Line	Historic Finland / Russian front fortification line
17th Parallel	Historical North & South Vietnam boundary line (also claimed line in Sir Creek / Rann of Kutch disputes)
Rio Grande	Forms much of **USA–Mexico** border
Alpine / Little Maginot	France–Italy fortification line
Siegfried Line	German fortification facing the French Maginot Line

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q32

MacMohan line forms the boundary between

Options:

A. India and China

B. India and Pakistan

C. India and Myanmar

D. India and Nepal

Show answer

Ans: A — Paper spelling **MacMohan**. India–China (Arunachal).

N.4 Coastline and coastal states

Identity: India's coastline includes the mainland plus the island groups. The total is about **7,516.6 km**.

Mainland + islands: ≈ **7,516.6 km** · **Nine** coastal states

The nine coastal states are Gujarat, Maharashtra, Goa (गोवा), Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu (नाडु), Andhra Pradesh, Odisha and West Bengal.

Coastal Union Territories include Andaman & Nicobar, Lakshadweep (लक्षद्वीप), Puducherry and Daman & Diu (inside DN&DD).

The longest **state** coastline is **Gujarat**.

Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu are the usual next names.

The shortest coastal state is **Goa**.

The Andaman and Nicobar coastline is very long.

If the options are States, the answer remains **Gujarat**.

Telangana is **not** a coastal state.

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q98

Which of the following States of India has the longest coastline?

Options:

A. Maharashtra

B. Andhra Pradesh

C. Kerala

D. Gujarat

Show answer

Ans: D

N.5 Countries and capitals

Identity: Capitals are match-list facts. Famous commercial cities are often **not** the capital.

Neighbourhood

Pakistan's capital is **Islamabad**.

Karachi is not Pakistan's capital.

Afghanistan's capital is **Kabul**.

China's capital is **Beijing**.

Nepal's capital is **Kathmandu**.

Bhutan's capital is **Thimphu**.

Myanmar's capital is **Naypyidaw**.

Yangon is Myanmar's old capital / major port (बंदरगाह), not the present capital.

Bangladesh's capital is **Dhaka**.

Sri Lanka's official capital is **Sri Jayawardenepura Kotte**.

Colombo is Sri Lanka's commercial city.

The Maldives' capital is **Mal (माल)é**.

Central Asia capitals (match bank)

2019 asked four (चातुर्याम) "Stan" capitals. Next paper can still pick **Kazakhstan** or swap names. Learn the full set. Starred rows mark the 2019 order.

Country	Capital	Trap
Uzbekistan ★	**Tashkent**	—
Tajikistan ★	**Dushanbe**	Not Ashgabat
Kyrgyzstan ★	**Bishkek**	—
Turkmenistan ★	**Ashgabat**	Not Dushanbe
Kazakhstan	**Astana** (Nur-Sultan phase)	Almaty is **not** the capital
Afghanistan	Kabul	Neighbourhood
Iran	Tehran	Neighbourhood

2019 paper order: Uzbekistan → Tajikistan → Kyrgyzstan → Turkmenistan.

Capitals that are not the famous city

- Australia — **Canberra**, not Sydney/Melbourne.
- Brazil — **Brasília**, not Rio.
- Nigeria — **Abuja**, not Lagos.
- Tanzania — **Dodoma**, not Dar es Salaam.
- Turkey — **Ankara**, not Istanbul.
- South Africa — three capitals (Pretoria, Cape Town, Bloemfontein); Johannesburg is not one.
- Netherlands — Amsterdam. **The Hague** is the government / ICJ seat.
- Côte d'Ivoire — Yamoussoukro, not Abidjan.
- Bolivia — Sucre (constitutional), La Paz (seat of government).
- Cape Verde — **Praia**. **Bamako** is Mali (2020 NOT matched).
- Benin — Porto-Novo, not Cotonou.
- Maghreb correct pairs: Morocco–Rabat, Tunisia–Tunis, Algeria–Algiers.
- Slovenia's capital is **Ljubljana**. Bratislava is **Slovakia**.
- Peru's capital is **Lima**. Austria's capital is **Vienna** (IAEA HQ). North Korea's capital is **Pyongyang** (Seoul is South Korea).
- Myanmar's capital is **Nay Pyi Taw** / Naypyidaw (moved from Yangon / Pyinmana area).

- Palestine map pair: **Ramallah**. Kosovo: **Pristina**. Taiwan: **Taipei**.

N.5A Country ranks · regions · dependent territories · old names

Area (largest →): Russia → Canada → USA → China → Brazil → Australia → **India (7th)** → Argentina → Kazakhstan → Algeria. Ascending Argentina → India → Australia → Brazil is a classic code.

Coastline longest (approximate coaching order — lengths move with measurement scale): Canada is first by a wide margin. Then come **Indonesia**, **Russia**, the **Philippines**, **Japan**, and **Australia**. Some atlases insert **Norway** (fjords) or **Greenland** (Denmark) high in the list; treat Canada as the safe lead and the rest as the usual top set.

India's longest land border: Bangladesh.

South Asia area: India largest; **Maldives** smallest. South Asia ≈ Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Afghanistan.

Region	Members / pair
Horn of Africa	Djibouti, Eritrea, Ethiopia, **Somalia — not Sudan**
Balkans	Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Bulgaria, Croatia, Greece, Kosovo, Montenegro, North Macedonia, Romania, Serbia, Slovenia, and European Türkiye (Eastern Thrace). **Austria is not** Balkan.
Scandinavia (geo)	Norway, Sweden, Denmark — Finland often cultural/historical set but MCQ may exclude Finland
Central America	Belize, Costa Rica, El Salvador, Guatemala, Honduras, Nicaragua, Panama — **not Sierra Leone** (W Africa)
Oceania	Melanesia / Micronesia / Polynesia + Australia — **Indonesia not** Oceania
Arabian Peninsula	Saudi Arabia, Yemen, Oman, UAE, Bahrain, Qatar, Kuwait (+ Iraq fringe) — **Syria not**
UAE emirates	Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah, Ajman, Umm Al-Quwain, Fujairah, Ras Al-Khaimah
Gaza Strip	Borders **Egypt** and **Israel** (Mediterranean strip)
Caspian shores	Russia, Kazakhstan, Turkmenistan, Iran, Azerbaijan — **not Armenia / Iraq**
Dead Sea	Israel / West Bank / Jordan — **not Lebanon**
Afghanistan neighbours	Iran, Pakistan, China, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, Turkmenistan (+ India SE note) — **not Russia / Azerbaijan / Kyrgyzstan**
Myanmar neighbours	India, Bangladesh, China, Laos, Thailand — **not Vietnam/Cambodia/Malaysia as the trio**
Israel land borders	Lebanon, Syria, Jordan, Egypt
Chile	Longest N–S extension among common traps (W South America)
Japan	Largest among common "island without land border" options vs NZ / Philippines / Cuba

Region	Members / pair
Indonesia land borders	Malaysia, Papua New Guinea, Timor-Leste — **not Brunei**

Dependent territories (one-liners)

Place	Owner / note
Greenland	Denmark politically; geographically **N America**; largest island
Christmas Island	Australia (Indian Ocean)
Martinique	France (Caribbean)
Falklands / St Helena / Gibraltar / Pitcairn / BIOT	UK
Puerto Rico / American Samoa / US Virgin / Midway	USA
Canaries / Ceuta / Melilla / Balearics	Spain
Azores / Madeira	Portugal
Cook / Niue / Tokelau / Ross Dependency	NZ association
Chechnya	Republic of **Russia** (Caucasus; capital Grozny)
Aleutian	USA; **Bear** Norway; **Franz Josef** Russia

Old → new names

Old Name	New Name
Siam	**Thailand**
Formosa	**Taiwan**
Mesopotamia (मेसोपोटामिया)	**Iraq**
Burma	**Myanmar**
Gold Coast	**Ghana** (घन)
Dutch Guiana	**Suriname**
Dutch East Indies	**Indonesia**
British Guiana	**Guyana**
Southern Rhodesia	**Zimbabwe** (capital Harare was Salisbury)
Northern Rhodesia	**Zambia**
Abyssinia	**Ethiopia**

Old Name	New Name
Basutoland	**Lesotho**
Bechuanaland	**Botswana**
Zaire	**Republic of the Congo / DR Congo**
Nyasaland	**Malawi**
South West Africa	**Namibia**
Dahomey	**Benin**
Upper Volta	**Burkina Faso**
Ceylon	**Sri Lanka**
Batavia	**Jakarta**
Peking	**Beijing**
Angora	**Ankara**
Constantinople	**Istanbul**
Saigon	**Ho Chi Minh City**
Petrograd / Leningrad	**St. Petersburg**
Stalingrad	**Volgograd**

Landlocked extras

- **Laos** is the only classic landlocked sovereign state in mainland Southeast Asia.
- **Chad** is a frequent African landlocked option.
- North America and Oceania have **no** classic landlocked sovereign states.
- Transcontinental coaching names include **Georgia** and **Türkiye**.
- Russia, Azerbaijan and Kazakhstan also bridge Asia–Europe frames.
- **South Sudan** is landlocked. Its capital is **Juba**. It sits on the White Nile.
- **Bolivia** is landlocked. Suriname, Uruguay and Peru are not.

World towns pairs: Most megacities are coastal because they are **ocean-route gateways**. Alaska is part of the USA. Malta sits in the Mediterranean. Silicon Valley city lists exclude Santa Rosa. South Africa's Parliament seat is **Cape Town**. Lhasa ranks among the highest capitals/towns. Baikonur is in **Kazakhstan** (not Ukraine). The Kanto plain is in **Japan**. The Congo sits in **Africa**. Mexico is in **North America**.

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2019, Q2

Match List-I with List-II:

List-I (Country)	List-II (Capital)
A. Uzbekistan	1. Tashkent

List-I (Country)	List-II (Capital)
B. Tajikistan	2. Dushanbe
C. Kyrgyzstan	3. Bishkek
D. Turkmenistan	4. Ashgabat

Options:

A. 1 2 3 4

B. 1 2 4 3

C. 1 3 4 2

D. 1 4 2 3

Show answer

Ans: A

N.5B Geographical sobriquets

Geographical sobriquets are coaching nicknames for countries, cities, and regions. Learn the **pair**, not a story dump.

Midnight Sun

- Visible at local midnight north of the **Arctic Circle** or south of the **Antarctic Circle** near summer solstice (~21 June N / ~22 December S).
- **Norway** is the classic **Land of the Midnight Sun**. Parts of Canada, Sweden, Russia, Iceland, and Finland also see it.
- No sovereign country sits between the Antarctic Circle and the South Pole, so the southern case is polar/expedition framing, not a country nickname.

World country / region nicknames

Sobriquet	Place
Land of the Midnight Sun	**Norway** (Arctic set)
Bird Continent / Continent of Birds	**South America**
Mistress of the Eastern Sea / Pearl of the Indian Ocean	**Sri Lanka**
Gateway to Asia	**Singapore**
Land of White Elephants	**Thailand**
Land of the Rising Sun / Nippon	**Japan**
Land of Thousand Lakes / Garden of Lakes	**Finland**

Sobriquet	Place
Land of Morning Calm	**(South) Korea**
Dark Continent	**Africa**
Land of Thunderbolts	**Bhutan**
Land of Golden Pagodas	**Myanmar**
Land of Kangaroos	**Australia**
Britain of the South	**New Zealand**
Key of the Mediterranean	**Gibraltar**
Holy Land	Palestine / Jerusalem
Sick Man of Europe	**Türkiye**
Playground of Europe	**Switzerland**
Island of Cloves	**Zanzibar**
Pearl of the Antilles / Sugar Bowl of the World	**Cuba**
Island of Pearls / Pearl of the Persian (फ़ारसी) Gulf	**Bahrain**
Gift of the Nile	**Egypt**
Land of Canals	**Pakistan** (coaching tag)
Blue Grass State	**Kentucky** (USA)
Land of Promise	**Mindanao** (Philippines)

City / feature nicknames

Sobriquet	Place
Venice of the North	**St. Petersburg** (Russia) / Stockholm (Sweden)
Gateway to the West	**Istanbul**
City of Canals / Queen of the Adriatic / City of Dreams	**Venice** (Italy)
City of Seven Hills / Eternal City	**Rome** (Italy)
Manchester of the East / Nation’s Kitchen	**Osaka** (Japan)
City of the Golden Gate	**San Francisco** (USA)
City of Sky Scrapers / Windy City / City of Smoke	**New York** (Sky Scrapers) / **Chicago** (Windy City / Smoke)
City of Dreaming Spires	**Oxford** (England)
Granite City	**Aberdeen** (Scotland)

Sobriquet	Place
Cockpit of Europe	**Belgium**
Forbidden City	**Lhasa** (Tibet)
Gate of Tears	**Bab-el-Mandeb**
Herring Pond	**Atlantic Ocean**
Hermit Kingdom	**Korea**
Island Continent / Land of Golden Fleece	**Australia**
Pillars of Hercules	**Strait of Gibraltar**
Pearl of the Pacific	**Guayaquil Port** (Ecuador)
Paris of South America	**Buenos Aires** (Argentina)
Empire City	**New York**
Oil Capital of Europe	**Aberdeen**
Pearl of Siberia	**Lake Baikal** (Russia)
Roof of the World	**Pamir** (Central Asia)

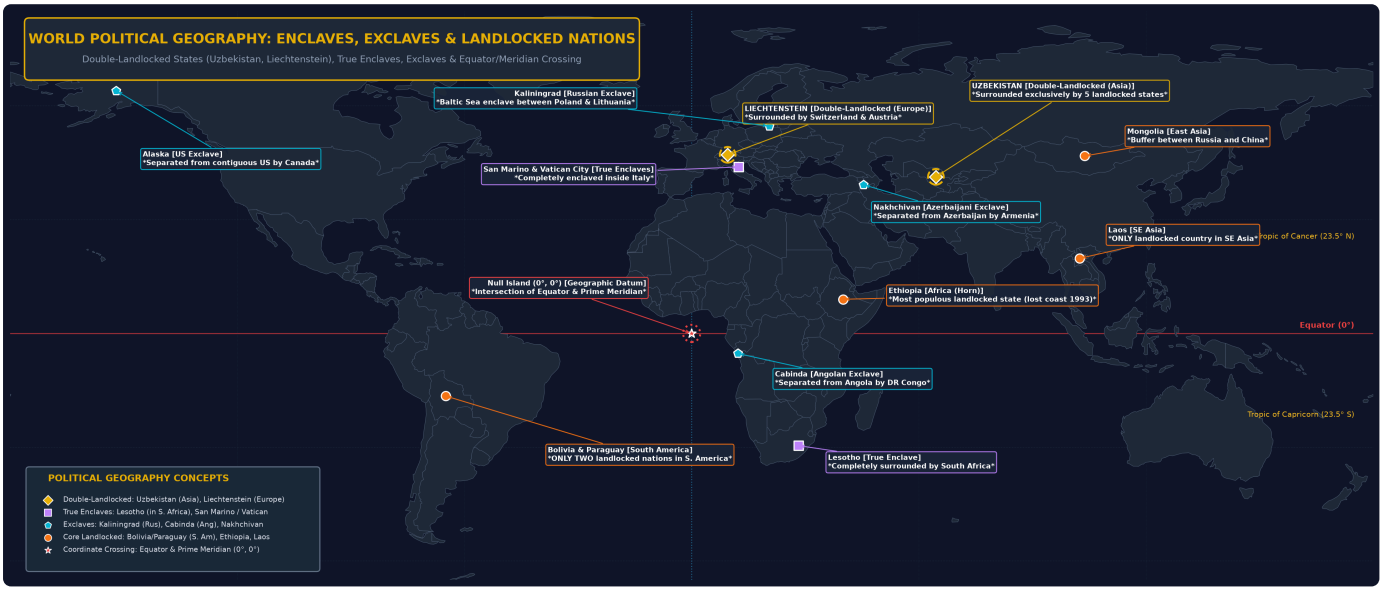
India sobriquets (map desk)

Sobriquet	Place
City of Golden Temple (स्वर्ण मंदिर)	Amritsar (अमृतसर)
Land of Five Rivers	Punjab
Gateway of India / City of Seven Islands	Mumbai
Queen of the Arabian Sea	Kochi (Cochin)
Spice Garden of India	Kerala
Switzerland of India	Kashmir
Twin Cities	Hyderabad (हैदराबाद)–Secunderabad
Manchester of India	Ahmedabad (अहमदाबाद)
Venice of the East	Alappuzha (Alleppey)
Sorrow of Bengal	Damodar (दामोदर)
Sorrow of Bihar	Kosi (कोसी)
Sorrow of China	Huang He (Hwang Ho)
Queen of Chotanagpur (छोटानागपुर)	Netarhat (Jharkhand)
Queen of Mountains (India)	Mussoorie (मसूरी)

Sobriquet	Place
World's Bread Basket	Prairies of North America

Ocean ridge pair (often pasted near sobriquets in GC): Ninety East Ridge (90°E Ridge) lies in the **Indian Ocean**.

N.6 Landlocked, equator, islands



South America (2022 four)

- **Bolivia** is landlocked (with Paraguay).
- Uruguay, Suriname, Peru have coasts.

South Asia

- Landlocked: **Nepal, Bhutan**.
- Islands: Sri Lanka, Maldives.

Double landlocked (no coast and every neighbour is landlocked)

- **Uzbekistan**. **Liechtenstein**. Only these two in the usual Prelims fact.

Superlatives / enclaves

- Largest landlocked by **area** is **Kazakhstan** (Caspian shore does **not** cancel landlocked status).
- Most populous landlocked is **Ethiopia** (Eritrea took the Red Sea coast).
- **Lesotho** is an enclave wholly inside **South Africa**. **Eswatini** (Swaziland) is also landlocked in southern Africa but not a full enclave like Lesotho.
- Europe's smallest landlocked names are Vatican City, San Marino and Liechtenstein.

Africa — frequent landlocked names

- Ethiopia, South Sudan, Chad, Niger, Mali, Burkina Faso, CAR, Uganda, Rwanda, Burundi, Zambia, Zimbabwe, Malawi, Botswana, Lesotho, Eswatini.

Equator passes through

- South America: Ecuador, Colombia, Brazil.
- Africa: Gabon, Congo, DRC, Uganda, Kenya, Somalia.
- Asia/Pacific: Indonesia, Kiribati.
- Does **not** pass through Egypt, Mexico, India, South Africa, Argentina.

Tropic of Cancer countries (set)

- Mexico, Bahamas fringe, Western Sahara/Mauritania/Mali/Algeria/Niger/Libya/Egypt, Saudi Arabia, UAE/Oman fringe, India, Bangladesh, Myanmar, China, Taiwan.

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q137

Which one of the following is a landlocked country?

Options:

A. Uruguay

B. Suriname

C. Peru

D. Bolivia

Show answer

Ans: D

N.7 Seas, gulfs, bays

Seas

- The Mediterranean sits between Europe, Africa and Asia. Its doors are Gibraltar and Suez.
- The Red Sea has Suez at the north and Bab el-Mandeb at the south.
- The Arabian Sea lies west of India. The Andaman Sea lies east of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands on the Malacca approach.
- The South China Sea holds the Spratly / Paracel disputes. The East China and Yellow Seas sit between China, Korea and Japan.
- The Sea of Japan and the Sea of Okhotsk lie in the north-west Pacific.
- The Black Sea outlets through the **Bosporus**.
- The Caspian is the largest lake, with five shores: Russia, Kazakhstan, Turkmenistan, Iran and Azerbaijan.
- The North Sea and Baltic are linked by the **Kiel Canal**.
- The Caribbean faces Panama's Atlantic side.
- The Bering Sea sits between Asia and America.
- The Coral and Tasman Seas belong with Australia.
- The Sargasso Sea sits in the Atlantic with no coasts.

Gulfs

- The Persian / Arab Gulf is an oil gulf. Its mouth is **Hormuz**. The Gulf of Oman is the outer side of Hormuz.
- Aden sits at Bab el-Mandeb. Aqaba and Suez are the two arms of the Red Sea.
- The Gulf of Mexico sits between the USA, Mexico and Cuba. Guinea faces West Africa. Thailand faces Bangkok.
- Carpentaria faces north Australia. California sits between Baja and mainland Mexico.
- Khambhat and Kutch face west India. Mannar sits between India and Sri Lanka.

Bays

- Bengal — east India; the big Indian- bay.
- Hudson — Canada. Fundy — highest tide renown. Baffin — Canadian Arctic.
- Biscay — France-Spain. Ha Long — Vietnam.

N.8 Straits

Strait of Hormuz

Joins: Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman · **Sides:** Iran / UAE–Oman

- World oil chokepoint. Not Malacca.

Strait of Malacca

Joins: Andaman / Indian Ocean side and South China Sea · **Sides:** Malaysia–Indonesia (Singapore)

- Busiest Asia chokepoint. Tanker alternatives is Sunda, Lombok, Makassar.

Bering Strait

Joins: Arctic and Pacific · **Sides:** Russia and USA (Alaska)

Bosporus

Joins: Black Sea and Sea of Marmara · **Country:** Turkey (Istanbul)

- Dardanelles then take Marmara into the Aegean.

Strait of Gibraltar

Joins: Mediterranean and Atlantic · **Sides:** Spain / Rock of Gibraltar and Morocco

Other straits (list)

- Bab el-Mandeb — Red Sea and Gulf of Aden (Yemen–Djibouti/Eritrea).
- Palk — India and Sri Lanka, with Adam's Bridge.
- 10° Channel (दस डिग्री) — Andaman and Nicobar. 8°/9° Degree — Lakshadweep / Maldives side.
- Dover — North Sea and English Channel (UK–France).

- Magellan — Atlantic and Pacific inshore (Chile); Cape Horn is the open-ocean south.
- Torres — Australia and Papua New Guinea. Bass — Tasmania and Australia. Cook — NZ islands.
- Florida / Yucatán — doors of the Gulf of Mexico.
- Mozambique — Africa and Madagascar.
- Tsushima / Korea / Taiwan — East Asia.
- Davis / Denmark — Greenland–Canada / Iceland Arctic doors.

N.9 Canals

Suez Canal, 1869

Joins: Mediterranean Sea and Red Sea · **Note:** sea-level canal

- It does **not** itself touch the Atlantic or the open Indian Ocean. The 2025 water bodies are the **Red Sea and the Mediterranean**.
- Shortened India–Europe sea distance by about **7,000 km** (2018).
- Towns: Port Said (north), Ismailia, Suez (south).
- Lakes **north** → **south:** Manzala → Timsah → Great Bitter → Little Bitter (2019).

Panama Canal, 1914

Joins: Caribbean / Atlantic and Pacific · **Note:** ships climb stepped chambers, plus **Gatun Lake**

- Avoids Cape Horn. Not Med–Red.

Kiel Canal

Joins: North Sea and Baltic · **Country:** Germany

- Corinth is Ionian and Aegean (Greece).
- St Lawrence (लॉरेंस) Seaway is Great Lakes and Atlantic.
- Rhine–Main–Danube is North Sea inland to the Black Sea.

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q138

The Suez Canal connects which of the following?

1. Atlantic Ocean
2. Red Sea
3. Mediterranean Sea
4. Indian Ocean

Options:

A. 1 and 3

B. 3 and 4

C. 2 and 3

D. 1 and 2

Show answer

Ans: C

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q29

How much the maritime distance between India and Europe was reduced after the construction of the Suez Canal?

Options:

A. 5,000 km

B. 7,000 km

C. 8,000 km

D. 10,000 km

Show answer

Ans: B

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2019, Q76

In the Suez canal region, the correct order of lakes lying from North to South direction is

Options:

A. Lake Timsah-Little Bitter Lake-Great Bitter Lake-Luke Manzola

B. Great Bitter Lake - Little Bitter Lake-Lake Timsah-Lake Manzala

C. Lake Manzala - Great Bitter Lake - Little Bitter Lake-Lake Timsah

D. Lake Manzala-Lake Timsah- Cireat Bitter Lake-Little Bitter Lake

Show answer

Ans: D

N.10 Mountains (map)

Range–region match bank (next year can ask any)

2024 asked only a **west** → **east** four-pack. Learn the atlas bank. Starred rows mark that paper's set.

Range / highland	Region / country fact	Tag
Pontic ★	Northern **Turkey** (Black Sea side)	2024 W→E
Zagros ★	Western **Iran**	2024 W→E

Range / highland	Region / country fact	Tag
Hindu Kush ★	**Afghanistan** (into N Pakistan)	2024 W→E
Karakoram (काराकोरम) ★	N Pakistan / Ladakh / China border	2024 W→E; K2
Alps	**Europe** (France–Switzerland–Italy–Austria)	Mont Blanc
Atlas	NW **Africa** (Morocco–Algeria–Tunisia)	
Andes	**South America** (spine)	Aconcagua in Argentina
Rockies	**North America** (W USA–Canada)	
Appalachians	Eastern **USA**	Older fold belt
Urals	**Russia** — Europe / Asia conventional divide	
Caucasus	Russia / Georgia / Azerbaijan belt	**Elbrus** (Europe peak)
Drakensberg	**South Africa** / Lesotho	
Great Dividing Range	**Australia** (east)	
Pamir	Tajikistan / "Roof of the World" knot	
Tien Shan	Central Asia / China–Kyrgyzstan	
Kunlun	North of Tibetan Plateau (**China**)	
Altai	Russia / Mongolia / China / Kazakhstan	
Ethiopian Highlands	**Ethiopia** / Horn of Africa	

West → east (2024 asked order): Pontic (N Turkey) → Zagros (W Iran) → Hindu Kush (Afghanistan) → Karakoram.

- The paper code is **2, 4, 3, 1** when Karakoram is 1, Pontic is 2, Hindu Kush is 3 and Zagros is 4.

Highest peak by continent (match bank)

Continent	Peak	Country fact / trap
Asia	**Everest**	Nepal–China
South America	**Aconcagua**	**Argentina**
North America	**Denali**	USA (Alaska)
Africa	**Kilimanjaro**	**Tanzania** (not Kenya)
Europe	**Elbrus**	Russia / Caucasus
Australia (mainland)	**Kosciuszko**	Australia
Antarctica	Vinson Massif	Also revise

- Nobi and Kanto plains is **Japan**, not Korea/China (2021).

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q76

Consider the following mountains and arrange them in correct order from West to East by their location:

1. Karakoram
2. Pontic
3. Hindu Kush
4. Zagros

Options:

A. 2, 4, 3, 1

B. 2, 3, 4, 1

C. 4, 2, 3, 1

D. 4, 1, 2, 3

Show answer

Ans: A — Pontic → Zagros → Hindu Kush → Karakoram.

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2021, Q55

Nobi and Kanto plains are located in which of the following countries?

Options:

A. North Korea

B. South Korea

C. Japan

D. China

Show answer

Ans: C

N.11 Rivers and lakes (map)

Identity: This is the **quick map desk** for world mouths and lake–country pairs.

The **Nile** opens into the Mediterranean.

The **Amazon** and the **Congo** open into the Atlantic.

The **Mississippi** opens into the Gulf of Mexico and builds a bird's-foot (पक्षी-पाद) delta (डेल्टा).

The **Danube** opens into the Black Sea.

The **Volga** opens into the Caspian Sea.

The **Rhine** reaches the North Sea at Rotterdam.

The **Murray–Darling** drains southern Australia.

The **Darling Range** sits on the south-west Australian coast and is **not** this river system.

The **Mekong** delta is in **southern Vietnam**, not Cambodia as the sea mouth.

The **Irrawaddy** opens into the Andaman Sea.

The **Indus** (सिंधु) opens into the Arabian Sea.

The **Ganga (गंगा)–Brahmaputra (ब्रह्मपुत्र)** opens into the Bay of Bengal.

The **Huang He** opens into the Yellow Sea.

The **Yangtze** opens into the East China Sea.

The **Amur** opens on the north-east Pacific / Tatar Strait side.

The **Caspian** is the largest lake and touches five countries.

Superior is the largest freshwater Great Lake by area.

Baikal is the deepest lake and sits in Russia.

Baikal's sobriquet is **Pearl of Siberia**.

Victoria, Tanganyika and Malawi are the East African lake set.

Titicaca sits on the Peru–Bolivia border.

Eyre is Australia's large ephemeral lake.

The **Dead Sea** sits on the Jordan–Israel border and is the lowest land surface.

The **Aral Sea** is shrinking between Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan.

Manzala, Timsah and the Bitter Lakes sit on the **Suez** route.

N.12 Ports (map)

Identity: Match each port to its **country** and one trap. Volume ranks move; identity does not.

Rotterdam is in the **Netherlands**.

Hamburg is in Germany.

Antwerp is in Belgium.

Duisburg is an inland Rhine port.

Shanghai is China's great container port.

Singapore is the classic Malacca entrepôt.

Jakarta is Indonesia's capital port city.

Montevideo is in **Uruguay**.

Montevideo is **not** Buenos Aires.

Igarka is in **Russia** on the Yenisei timber route.

Igarka is **not** in China.

Port Said and **Suez** are Egyptian ends of the canal.

Mumbai, JNPT, Chennai and Kolkata are India's main matched ports on this desk.

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q60

Which of the following (**Port — Country**) is **not** correctly matched?

Options:

A. Rotterdam — Netherlands

B. Igarka — China

C. Montevideo — Uruguay

D. Jakarta — Indonesia

Show answer

Ans: B

N.13 Köppen climate

Identity: The quote *"Vegetation is the true index of climate"* is linked to **Thornthwaite** in UPPCS. **Köppen** built the **letter-code** climate classification using vegetation, temperature, and precipitation — do not swap the two facts.

- **Af** — tropical rainforest, rain all year (Amazon, Congo, Indonesia).
- **Am** — tropical monsoon (west-coast India, parts of SE Asia).
- **Aw** — savanna (सवाना), wet–dry (Deccan (दक्कन), African savanna, Brazilian cerrado).
- **BWh** — hot desert (Sahara, Arabia, Thar (थार), Australia interior).
- **BWk** — cold desert (Gobi). **BSh/BSk** — steppe (Sahel, Prairie (प्रेयरी) edge).
- **Cs** — Mediterranean: **winter rain**, dry summer; five west-coast patches.
- **Cfa** — humid subtropical (SE USA, east China).
- **Cfb** — marine west coast with rain in **all months**. Classic home is **Western Europe** under the westerlies (2024 both).
- **Df/Dw** — humid continental / subarctic (Canada, Siberia).
- **ET** — tundra (टुंड्रा). **EF** — ice cap. **H** — highland (Tibet, Andes).
- Mediterranean: at the Northern Hemisphere winter solstice, belts shift **south** and westerlies cover the Med (2024 both). Summer is dry under the subtropical high / dry land winds (2022 A/R — both true, R explains).

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q25

'Vegetation is the true index of climate'. This statement is associated with

Options:

A. Thornthwaite

B. Koppen

C. Trewartha

D. Stamp

Show answer

Ans: A — **Thornthwaite**. Köppen is the letter-code classification trap.

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q79

Consider the following statements with reference to Mediterranean climate:

1. It receives rainfall in winter season.
2. Due to winter solstice, air pressure belts shift to the south.

Which of the above statements is/are correct?

Options:

A. Only 2

B. Neither 1 nor 2

C. Only 1

D. Both 1 and 2

Show answer

Ans: D

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q75

Consider the following statements with respect to the climate of Western Europe:

1. Western Europe receives rainfall in all months.
2. Western Europe is located in the belt of Westerlies.

Which of the above statements is/are correct?

Options:

A. Both 1 and 2

B. Neither 1 nor 2

C. Only 1

D. Only 2

Show answer

Ans: A

Inline PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q144Assertion (A): Rainfall occurs in the winter season in Mediterranean climate.

Reason (R): In summer these regions remain under the influence of dry terrestrial winds.

Options:

A. (A) is false but (R) is true.

B. (A) is true but (R) is false.

C. Both (A) and (R) are true but (R) is not the correct explanation of (A).

D. Both (A) and (R) are true and (R) is the correct explanation of (A).

Show answer

Ans: D
